
British-American author and critic Bonnie Greer dies aged 77

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Paul Glynn, Culture reporter



Getty Images: Greer's work often tackled topics around culture, race and public institutions

British-American author and cultural commentator Bonnie Greer has died at the age of 77 after a brief illness, her husband has said.

In a statement delivered with “profound sadness”, Greer’s widower David Hutchins noted how the acclaimed playwright and critic had made “an enduring contribution to British cultural and public life” with her “intelligence, courage and distinctive voice”.

He added: “To me, she was my partner, confidante and inspiration, and I feel profoundly privileged to have shared my life with her.”

Hutchins continued: “Those closest to Bonnie will remember her warmth, humour, generosity and extraordinary ability to bring people together.”

‘Courage, humour and humanity’

BBC presenter Clive Myrie led the tributes from elsewhere, posting on X: “This is such a shock. She was a friend and mentor and I will miss her with all my heart.”

Former deputy prime minister David Lammy called Greer “a powerful wordsmith and artist, she was eloquent and exacting”.

He added that she was “a true life force” and he would “never forget her quiet fearlessness taking on Nick Griffin” during an appearance with the then-British National Party (BNP) leader on the BBC’s Question Time in 2009.

Lammy added: “I will miss her mentorship, and her friendship.”

London Mayor Sadiq Khan said Greer’s voice brought “courage, humour and humanity to Britain’s cultural conversation”.

He said: “She inspired and opened doors for so many others. And she was great fun too - I will miss her friendship enormously.”

Plays, novels and panel shows

Born in Chicago in 1948, Greer wrote plays from a young age and went on to study theatre in her home city and before attending the Actors Studio in New York with director Elia Kazan.

Greer moved to the UK in 1986 and became a familiar face on UK TV, appearing as a frequent panellist on programmes like Question Time and Newsnight Review, debating the topics of the day.

She penned award-winning works like *Munda Negra*, which won her the Verity Bargate Award for best play, and novels such as *Hanging by Her Teeth* (1994) and *Entropy* (2009).

Once named by the Observer as one of the country’s leading public intellectuals, Greer’s work - across a range of disciplines and platforms - often tackled issues around culture, race and public institutions.



Getty Images: Greer was made an OBE for services to the arts in 2010

Speaking to the Guardian in 2016 in the aftermath of the Black Lives Matter movement, Greer said: “When I wake up in the morning, I’m just myself. It’s only when I leave the door that I become a black woman to the world.”

She added: “I tell black women all the time, ‘Don’t apologise for yourself and keep your hair nappy. Make sure you are heard’.”

Greer served on the boards of cultural institutions including the British Museum, Royal Opera House and London Film School, and was chancellor of London’s Kingston University.

Her other published works include a memoir titled *A Parallel Life* and a biography of US poet and playwright Langston Hughes.

Also in 2009, her part-memoir, part-music-history book, *Obama Music*, was published.

Greer was made an OBE in 2010 for services to the arts.

In 2022, she was appointed as a fellow of the Royal Society of Literature.

Broadcaster and author John Simpson added to the tributes on Wednesday, posting: “So sad to hear of the death of the writer and critic Bonnie Greer.

“She was a good friend, and gave me strong support at a time I needed it. Fiercely intelligent, but always avoided personal attacks. A huge loss.”

Fellow journalist and broadcaster Sangita Myska, who interviewed Greer several times, recalled her as having been a “smart, sassy, firebrand who will be missed from our public discourse”.

生词标注（新闻高频 + 词汇第二义项）

词	词性	中文	备注
tribute	n.	悼念、致敬（之词）	lead the tributes = 率先致哀
widower	n.	鳏夫	widow（寡妇）的男性形式
confidante	n.	知己、密友	女性密友；男性拼 confidant
playwright	n.	剧作家	play + wright（匠人）
wordsmith	n.	文字大师、文字匠	word + smith（铁匠）
exacting	adj.	严格较真的、要求高的	形容人 / 标准；动词 exact = 索取
pen	v.	执笔撰写	She penned...；名词“钢笔”
board	n.	理事会、董事会	serve on the boards；第二义项非“木板”
chancellor	n.	（大学）名誉校长	英国大学最高名誉职；另一义“（财政）大臣”
fellow	n.	（学会）院士、会员	RSL fellow；第二义项非“家伙”
discourse	n.	公共话语、讨论	public discourse 公共言说
firebrand	n.	斗士、敢言闯将	热情好斗之人（略含“惹火”色彩）
sassy	adj.	泼辣、时髦敢言的	口语褒义
take on	短语	与……交锋、迎战	take sb on；此处取“迎战”义（另有“承担”义，如 take on work）
in the aftermath of	短语	在……的余波中	aftermath = 后果、余波
recall	v.	回忆道、追忆	第二义项：不是“召回”
public intellectual	n.	公共知识分子	就公共议题公开发声的学者作家

词	词性	中文	备注
the then-...	前缀	当时的.....	the then-BNP leader 时任党魁
make an OBE	短语	获授 OBE 勋章	make = 授予；OBE = 英帝国官佐勋章